Thread and Needle Cheat Chart

Print once, tape it inside your sewing basket. It answers the only two questions that matter at the start of a mend: which thread, and which needle.

Which thread should I use?

YOU'RE FIXING	THREAD TO PICK	WHY
Everyday shirt or pants buttons	All-purpose polyester, doubled	Strong and stretchy; won't break when the button flexes
Coat button or heavy jacket	Heavy-duty or doubled all-purpose, quadrupled	Coat buttons take real strain
Jeans, denim, workwear	Heavy-duty polyester or topstitch thread	Survives friction and repeated washing
Knits and sweaters	Matching yarn or fine wool thread	Moves with the fabric; polyester thread feels stiff
Delicates, silk, lining	Fine cotton or silk thread, single strand	Too-thick thread bulks up fine fabric
Zippers, bags, repairs under strain	Heavy-duty polyester	Weak thread is why zips keep failing

Which needle should I use?

FABRIC	NEEDLE	REMEMBER
Woven (shirts, denim, linen)	Sharp needle, size 9–11	Small needle, small hole, invisible mends
Knits, sweaters, Jersey	Blunt tapestry or ballpoint needle	Blunt tips slide between the yarns instead of piercing them
Heavy layers (hems, coats)	Mid-size sharp, size 7–9	Poke through with a thimble, not shoulder strength
Beads, buttons on heavy fabric	Mid-size sharp	Pass the button three or four times and stop there
Silk and fine fabrics	The finest needle you have	Fine needle leaves no mark behind

Quick translator

WHAT YOU'LL HEAR	PLAIN MEANING
Sharps vs. tapestry needles	Pointed tip vs. rounded tip. Pointed for woven fabric, rounded for knits.

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Needle “sizes” (5, 7, 9, 11)	Higher number = finer needle. Start at 9 for cloth work; 3–5 for tough jobs.
“Single” vs. “doubled” thread	One strand through the needle vs. two, tied together. Doubled is faster and stronger.
Thread “weight” (30, 40, 50)	Higher = thinner thread. Heavy-duty threads are the low numbers.
Slipstitch, whipstitch, running stitch	Hiding stitches in a fold vs. looping around an edge vs. a simple straight ladder.

Kind tips: If you're between options, the all-purpose thread and a medium sharp needle will get 90 percent of home mends done. You could buy an entire wardrobe of needles and never outgrow that one.